

Sufi poetry

Amir Khusrau was court poet for several of the Delhi sultans and a follower of the Sufi (Islamic mystic) saint Nizammudin. His poetry, an example of which is shown here, is sung today in the devotional music called *Qawwali*.



of the 11 sultans were assassinated. In 1258, refugees fleeing the destruction of Baghdad by the nomadic

Mongols (see pp.162–65) came to India, bringing with them new ideas of the divine right of kings and the rituals of the Persian courts of the Sassanids (see pp.122–23). Imperial authority grew stronger as a result, although tribal loyalties and intrigues remained divisive.

Throughout the period of the Delhi Sultanate, the sultans based their policies on pragmatism, rather than the *Sharia* (Islamic) law. Some Hindu temples in zones of military conflict were destroyed, but this had been a military tactic in India before the arrival of the Muslims and there does

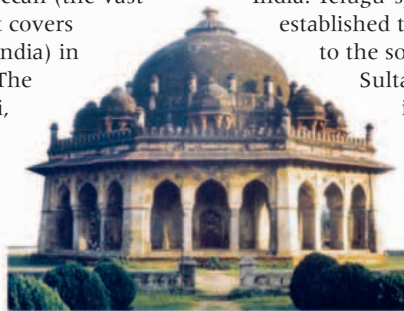
not seem to have been a policy of temple destruction. In settled areas, temple building and renovation was sanctioned by the state. Subjects were permitted to practice their own faiths, and the *Jizya* tax, which non-Muslims are supposed to pay in an Islamic state, was only enforced sporadically.

Expansion to the south

Between 1299–1305, sultan Alauddin Khilji launched a series of successful military expeditions against the various rich kingdoms south of Delhi, including the Yadava capital of Devagiri, the Somnath temple in Gujarat, Chittorgarh in Rajasthan, and Mandu in central India. In 1311, Alauddin sent his favorite slave, Malik Kafur, on a series of raids into the Deccan (the vast plateau region that covers much of southern India) in search of plunder. The Yadavas of Devagiri, the Kakatiyas of

Lodi Tomb

The Lodi Dynasty, the last dynasty of the Sultanate, ruled from 1451 to 1526. Several octagonal Lodi tombs still stand in Delhi.



Warangal, and the Pandyas of Madurai were all defeated. Their kings were reinstated, but had to acknowledge the sultan's overlordship and send him an annual tribute. After Alauddin's death in 1305, the southern kingdoms stopped paying tribute, and so in 1321 Sultan Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq sent his son Muhammad to annex them. The kings were replaced with governors.

The emperor's new capital

After he became sultan, Muhammad bin Tughlaq (reigned 1324–51) moved the capital 700 miles (1,100 km) south to Devagiri, now renamed Daulatabad. In 1327–28 he forced the elite to relocate to Daulatabad, but within two years the inadequate water supply compelled him to reinstate Delhi as the capital.

Meanwhile, the empire began to fragment. New kingdoms and political elites, both Hindu and Muslim, came to power in the Deccan region of south

India. Telugu-speaking warriors established the Vijayanagar Empire to the south of the Delhi

Sultanate in the 1330s, and in 1345 the governors of the Deccan rebelled against Delhi and founded the Bahmani kingdom (see left).

By 1398, when the Mongol warrior Timur sacked and

Competing empires to the south weakened the sultanate, but it was a fresh invasion from Central Asia that finally supplanted it.

THE DECCANI SULTANATES

By the end of the 15th century, the **Bahmani** kingdom had fragmented into **five rival sultanates**, constantly at war with each other. In 1565 the **Vijayanagar Empire** was defeated by a rare combination of these five provinces.

THE MUGHALS

In 1525, **Babur**—a descendent of both Timur and Genghis Khan << **164–65**—marched from Kabul to India. He defeated the last of the Delhi Sultans at the **Battle of Panipat** in 1526 and established the **Mughal Dynasty 244–45**>>. The Mughals ruled India until the British removed the last king in 1858 at the start of the **British Raj 352–53**>>.

destroyed Delhi, the sultanate was no longer a major power. It continued until 1526 when the last of the sultans, Ibrahim Lodi, was defeated at Panipat, but was by then just one of many states contending for power in northern India.

Qutb Minar Complex

The Quwwat-ul-Islam ("Might of Islam") mosque in Delhi was constructed by Qutb-ud-din Aibek, founder of the Delhi Sultanate, as a symbol of his power. The sandstone base of the Qutb Minar is visible in the background.

1,600 The number of years that the inscribed iron pillar in the courtyard of the Qutb Minar complex has survived in the open air without any sign of rust. The great pillar dates back to the pre-Islamic empire of the Guptas.

